

Interview Study Guide

Manager, Patient Care Services — Integrated Forensic Program, The Royal

Candidate: Anne-Marie Brouse

Purpose: Same-day preparation for the interview

Your central message: You are an experienced mental-health and healthcare leader who can connect excellent clinical care with dependable daily operations, staff development, quality improvement, change leadership, and organizational strategy.

1. What the panel is likely looking for

This is not only a clinical leadership role. The posting describes a manager who is accountable for the daily functioning of a patient-care service: ensuring coordinated care, resolving escalated issues, supporting a multidisciplinary team, managing human-resources matters, implementing change, and aligning the unit with hospital priorities. The strongest answers will therefore combine **patient safety, staff support, operational reliability, recovery-oriented care, risk reduction, and measurable improvement**.

The Integrated Forensic Program serves individuals with serious mental illness who have had contact with the criminal justice system or may be at risk of doing so. In the interview, demonstrate that you understand the importance of balancing **therapeutic and recovery goals with risk management and public safety**, while preserving dignity, least-restrictive practice, professional boundaries, privacy, and collaborative care.

The panel may include operational, clinical, medical, human-resources, or senior leadership representatives. Expect a mixture of behavioural questions, situational scenarios, and questions about your motivation and leadership approach. Answer with a clear example whenever possible rather than speaking only in general terms.

2. Your strongest fit with the posting

Requirement or responsibility	Evidence from your resume	How to position it in the interview
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Oversee daily operations and coordinated service delivery	As Assistant Director, Youth Justice, you directed daily operations and multidisciplinary health and mental-health services.	Emphasize your ability to translate strategic priorities into reliable daily systems, staffing plans, communication routines, and follow-through.
Lead mental-health services	Current Advanced Practice Nurse role at The Royal; Mental Health Nurse with the Department of National Defence; mental-health nursing at CHEO; psychotherapy practice.	Explain that your clinical breadth helps you understand patient needs, staff realities, risk, and interdisciplinary decision-making.
Support clinical integration across disciplines	You have worked with multidisciplinary teams in youth justice, military mental health, CHEO, psychotherapy, and The Royal.	Describe how you establish shared goals, clarify roles, close communication gaps, and keep the patient's plan central.
Resolve sensitive or escalated issues	Complex mental-health clinical work, youth justice leadership, crisis-intervention certification, and organizational leadership.	Use a calm, structured approach: assess immediate safety, listen, identify the facts, involve the right people, act proportionately, document, and follow up.
Develop and motivate staff	Staff recruitment, performance management, workforce planning, staff development, education, mentoring, and clinical instruction.	Discuss psychological safety, coaching, clear expectations, recognition, accountability, and individualized development.
Manage human-resources issues	Direct experience with recruitment, performance management, workforce planning, and staff development as Assistant Director.	Be precise about what you have managed directly. Where you have not personally completed a specific union or termination process, say you would follow the collective agreement, policy, HR advice, and procedural fairness.
Mandatory training and policy implementation	Ottawa Public Health policy work; CHEO education and EHR implementation; current professional-practice leadership at The Royal.	Show that you use education, communication, tracking, reinforcement, audits, and feedback rather than assuming one announcement creates compliance.

Implement systems, workflows, or technology	Served as subject-matter expert and trainer during major EHR initiatives at CHEO; led evidence-informed practice and clinical transformation work.	Explain how you engage users, understand workflow impact, pilot or phase implementation, monitor adoption, and adjust based on data and feedback.
Quality improvement and accreditation	Led program evaluation, accreditation, and continuous quality improvement at Youth Services Bureau; supported accreditation and Ministry reporting at Ottawa Public Health; Lean Green and Yellow Belt certifications.	Use improvement language such as baseline, root cause, standard work, indicators, testing changes, and sustainability.
Use workforce and patient-care data	Workforce planning, budgeting, resource allocation, reporting, accreditation, and performance-improvement experience.	Mention that data should inform decisions without replacing clinical judgment. Discuss trends, variation, workload, outcomes, and staff/patient experience.
Work with senior stakeholders	Senior Management member, acting Director, Executive Management and Board of Health reporting, governance board membership, and current organizational committees.	Demonstrate upward communication, concise recommendations, transparency about risks, and alignment with broader strategy.
Required education and registration	MScN, BScN, BA in Psychology, College of Nurses of Ontario membership, and CNA psychiatric mental-health certification.	Connect nursing, psychology, mental-health, education, and leadership preparation to the role's clinical and administrative scope.

3. Your 60–90 second opening answer

You can adapt the following wording so it sounds natural rather than memorized:

“I am a registered nurse and mental-health leader with more than 20 years of experience across clinical practice, professional-practice leadership, education, quality improvement, public health, and healthcare operations. My background includes mental-health services at The Royal, military mental-health care, CHEO, psychotherapy, and operational leadership in Youth Justice Services, where I managed multidisciplinary

teams, staffing, workforce planning, performance management, budgets, accreditation, and service improvement. “In my current Advanced Practice Nurse role at The Royal, I support professional practice, clinical transformation, education, and quality improvement. I am interested in this manager position because it brings together the areas where I have developed the greatest strength: creating reliable care systems, developing teams, resolving complex issues, and translating organizational priorities into day-to-day practice. I am particularly drawn to the Integrated Forensic Program because it requires thoughtful mental-health care that balances recovery, risk reduction, collaboration, and public safety. I would bring clinical credibility, operational discipline, a coaching leadership style, and a strong commitment to patients, families, and staff.”

4. How to answer “Why this role and why The Royal?”

A strong answer should have three parts. First, explain the professional fit: the role combines mental-health leadership, operations, staff development, quality, and change. Second, explain the organizational connection: your current role gives you knowledge of The Royal’s professional-practice environment, while your earlier roles give you operational and multidisciplinary leadership experience. Third, explain the program connection: forensic mental-health care requires compassion, structure, sound risk thinking, and collaboration across clinical and justice-related contexts.

You could say:

“This role is a strong fit because it brings together clinical leadership and operational accountability. I have led multidisciplinary services, managed staffing and performance, supported accreditation and improvement, implemented education and technology changes, and provided mental-health care across several settings. My current work at The Royal has deepened my understanding of the organization and its commitment to professional practice and clinical transformation. I am ready to bring that experience into a role with direct accountability for daily patient-care operations and team performance. The Integrated Forensic Program is especially meaningful to me because high-quality care must support recovery while also addressing risk and public safety in a respectful, structured, and collaborative way.”

5. Keywords to use naturally

Theme	Useful language
Program purpose	Integrated forensic mental-health care; recovery-oriented care; trauma-informed care; person-centred care; risk reduction;

	public safety; therapeutic relationships; professional boundaries.
Leadership	Visible leadership; coaching; psychological safety; shared accountability; role clarity; staff engagement; development; respectful workplace; consistent follow-through.
Operations	Daily operational oversight; coordinated service delivery; patient flow; staffing plan; escalation pathway; continuity of care; workload balancing; reliable handoffs.
Human resources	Clear expectations; progressive performance management; attendance management; procedural fairness; collective agreement; documentation; early intervention; partnership with HR and labour relations.
Clinical governance	Patient safety; clinical judgment; escalation; documentation; consent and capacity; privacy; least restrictive approach; organizational policy; interdisciplinary case review.
Improvement	Evidence-informed practice; Lean; root-cause analysis; standard work; process mapping; measurable outcomes; PDSA-style testing; sustainability; audit and feedback.
Data and technology	EHR adoption; data integrity; clinical documentation; workforce indicators; patient-care indicators; trends; variation; dashboard; user engagement; workflow redesign.
Change	Stakeholder engagement; transparent communication; readiness assessment; implementation support; training; feedback loops; adoption; reinforcement; evaluation.

Use the legal terms in the posting accurately and in context: **Mental Health Act, PHIPA, and Substitute Decisions Act**, along with consent, capacity, confidentiality, documentation, and information sharing. Do not present yourself as giving legal advice. A safe interview formulation is: “I would apply the legislation, organizational policy, and clinical guidance, consult the appropriate experts when needed, document the rationale, and ensure the patient’s rights and safety remain central.”

6. Topics to review before the interview

Review the purpose of the Integrated Forensic Program and be ready to discuss the distinctive leadership demands of caring for people with serious mental illness who may be involved with the justice system. You do not need to pretend to have managed every forensic program function directly. Instead, connect your mental-health, youth-justice, military, psychotherapy, and hospital experience to the program's needs, and state clearly how you would learn local procedures and expectations.

Refresh your understanding of the practical implications of the legislation named in the posting. The panel will likely be more interested in your decision-making process than in reciting statutory language. Emphasize privacy, consent, capacity, lawful and necessary information sharing, careful documentation, consultation, and escalation through established channels.

Prepare to discuss unionized leadership even if your resume does not spell out every labour-relations responsibility. You can confidently describe your experience with recruitment, performance management, workforce planning, and staff development. For a question involving discipline, attendance, or termination, demonstrate that you would act early and fairly, clarify expectations, gather facts, document objectively, involve HR/labour relations, follow the collective agreement and policy, and maintain confidentiality.

7. Your adaptable STAR story bank

Story 1: Operational leadership at Youth Services Bureau of Ottawa

Use for: daily operations, multidisciplinary leadership, competing priorities, service quality, or team accountability.

Explain the service context and the complexity of the youth population. Describe how you organized daily operations, supported multidisciplinary teams, managed resources, and kept service goals on track. Finish with the result, such as improved coordination, stronger accountability, successful delivery, or progress against program goals. Add a specific metric if you can do so accurately.

Story 2: Staffing, performance, and workforce planning

Use for: HR leadership, difficult staff conversations, recruitment, retention, or staffing pressures.

Describe the workforce issue, how you assessed operational impact, how you communicated expectations, and what coaching, planning, or formal process you used. Highlight fairness and consistency. Explain the result for staff functioning, service coverage, or patient/client care.

Story 3: Acting Director experience

Use for: leadership under pressure, executive judgment, escalation, or decision-making during absence.

Describe how you assumed broader accountability, prioritized urgent matters, maintained communication with senior leaders, and ensured continuity. Emphasize knowing when to decide independently and when to escalate.

Story 4: EHR implementation at CHEO

Use for: technology, workflow redesign, training, resistance to change, or data quality.

Explain your role as subject-matter expert and trainer. Discuss how you translated the system into clinical workflow, supported staff learning, surfaced problems, and reinforced accurate documentation. Avoid claiming that you led the entire implementation if that was not your role.

Story 5: Accreditation and quality improvement

Use for: quality, patient safety, compliance, data, or sustainable improvement.

Describe the standard or problem, how you assessed current practice, engaged staff, created education or process changes, and monitored progress. Use your Lean training to explain root causes, standard work, testing changes, and sustainment.

Story 6: Evidence-informed practice at The Royal

Use for: current internal knowledge, clinical transformation, influence without formal authority, or organizational strategy.

Describe how you translated emerging evidence into practice, education, policy, or decision-making. Show how you consulted stakeholders and linked practice improvement to organizational priorities and patient outcomes.

Story 7: Complex mental-health clinical collaboration

Use for: risk, crisis, interdisciplinary disagreement, patient/family communication, or ethical complexity.

Use a real example from military mental health, CHEO, psychotherapy, or another setting. Structure the answer around assessment, immediate safety, collaboration, treatment or support planning, communication, documentation, and follow-up. Protect confidentiality and avoid identifying details.

Story 8: Building Integral Counselling & Psychotherapy

Use for: initiative, governance, accountability, systems creation, or entrepreneurship.

Explain how you developed policies, administrative systems, service processes, referral relationships, and regulatory-compliance practices while providing clinical care. Connect the experience to building sustainable systems and taking ownership of results.

8. Mock interview questions and answer focus

Question	What the panel wants to hear
Tell us about yourself and your leadership background.	A concise narrative connecting mental health, operations, people leadership, quality, and The Royal.
Why do you want this position?	Motivation for direct operational accountability and a credible connection to the Integrated Forensic Program.
Why move from your current Advanced Practice Nurse role so soon?	A positive, forward-looking answer: the current role has strengthened your organizational insight, and this position aligns with your broader operational leadership experience. Never criticize the current role.
What does effective patient-care management look like in a forensic mental-health setting?	Safe, coordinated, recovery-oriented care; risk reduction; public safety; clear roles; reliable communication; respectful and structured practice.
How would you prioritize competing operational demands on a busy day?	Triage by immediate safety and clinical risk, staffing and service continuity, time-sensitive patient needs, regulatory requirements, and impact; communicate priorities and delegate.
Tell us about a time you resolved an escalated or sensitive issue.	Calm assessment, listening, facts, safety, proportional action, consultation, documentation, and follow-up.
How do you build trust with a multidisciplinary team?	Visibility, respect for expertise, role clarity, shared goals, consistent decisions, psychological safety, and follow-through.
How would you address conflict between two staff members?	Meet privately, hear each perspective, focus on behaviour and impact, clarify expectations, facilitate resolution, document appropriately, and escalate if needed.

How do you handle an employee who is not meeting expectations?	Early direct feedback, specific expectations, support and coaching, documented follow-up, consistent process, HR/labour-relations consultation, and progressive action when necessary.
Describe your experience with attendance management.	Use only accurate examples. Emphasize timely conversations, objective documentation, support, policy/collective-agreement compliance, and partnership with HR.
How would you manage a union-related concern?	Respect the collective agreement, listen, avoid assumptions, document facts, apply consistent process, consult labour relations, and seek a workable solution without compromising safety or standards.
How would you respond to a patient-safety concern involving a staff member?	Protect immediate safety, assess and escalate, support the patient, preserve facts, follow reporting and investigation processes, and address learning or accountability.
What is your approach to risk in forensic mental health?	Structured assessment, dynamic reassessment, team formulation, clear plans, documentation, communication, least-restrictive principles where applicable, and escalation when risk changes.
How do PHIPA, the Mental Health Act, and the Substitute Decisions Act affect your leadership?	Protect privacy, understand consent/capacity and authority, share only necessary information through lawful channels, follow policy, consult experts, and document decisions.
Tell us about a change you led.	Stakeholder engagement, rationale, readiness, training, implementation support, feedback, adoption monitoring, and sustainability.
How would you introduce a new workflow that staff resist?	Understand the concern, involve users, clarify the patient-care problem, test or phase the change, provide support, measure impact, and address non-adoption fairly.
How have you used data to improve care or operations?	Combine patient-care, workforce, quality, experience, and process data; identify trends and variation; act; then reassess.

What indicators would you monitor in this role?	Safety events, patient flow/timeliness, care-plan completion, documentation quality, staffing/vacancy/absence trends, mandatory training, complaints/feedback, readmissions or other program-relevant outcomes, and staff experience. State that the exact dashboard should be agreed with leadership.
Tell us about a time you influenced without formal authority.	Current Advanced Practice Nurse, educator, policy, governance, or quality-improvement example with stakeholder engagement and a tangible outcome.
What would your first 90 days look like?	Listen and observe first; understand patients, staff, workflows, data, risks, policies, and relationships; identify quick wins; then co-create priorities and measures with the Director and team.
What is a leadership area you continue to develop?	Choose a genuine but manageable area, explain the strategy you use to improve, and show self-awareness without undermining readiness.
What questions do you have for us?	Thoughtful questions about success, priorities, team culture, challenges, onboarding, and measures.

Follow-up probes to practise

Be ready for the panel to ask, “What specifically did you do?” , “What was the result?” , “What would you do differently?” , “How did staff respond?” , “How did you measure success?” , “Who did you involve?” , and “What was the patient-care impact?” These probes are an invitation to add evidence, not to give a longer general answer.

9. Suggested answers to challenging areas

If asked about direct forensic-management experience

“My background includes extensive mental-health practice and leadership in complex populations, including youth justice, military mental health, tertiary pediatric mental health, psychotherapy, and my current role at The Royal. While I would not overstate experience that is specific to this exact forensic unit, I understand the importance of structured risk thinking, recovery, therapeutic boundaries, interdisciplinary

collaboration, documentation, and public safety. I would bring transferable leadership experience and would make learning the program’s local pathways, policies, and expectations an early priority.”

If asked about union relations or termination

“I have direct experience with recruitment, performance management, workforce planning, and staff development. In any unionized or termination-related matter, I would be fair, timely, and consistent: clarify expectations, gather facts, document objectively, meet with the employee, provide support and an opportunity to respond, and work closely with HR and labour relations while following the collective agreement and organizational policy. I would not improvise a process.”

If asked about a disagreement with a physician or senior stakeholder

“I would begin by clarifying the shared patient-care objective and ensuring I understand the clinical and operational concerns on both sides. I would bring the discussion back to evidence, policy, risk, and the patient’s needs, identify what can be agreed upon, and escalate through the appropriate pathway if the issue cannot be resolved. My goal would be a respectful decision with clear ownership and follow-up, not simply winning an argument.”

10. Questions to ask the panel

Question	Why it is useful
What are the most important priorities for this manager in the first six months?	Shows readiness to focus on organizational needs.
What are the current strengths and challenges of the team and service?	Invites an honest picture of culture, operations, and risk.
How do you define success in this role, and which measures are reviewed most often?	Connects your improvement and data background to accountability.
What operational or clinical issue would you most like the successful candidate to help stabilize or improve?	Helps you understand the immediate mandate.
How do the Manager, Director, physicians, allied health professionals, and frontline staff typically share decisions?	Demonstrates interest in interdisciplinary integration.

What support is available for onboarding into the program's forensic pathways, policies, and labour-relations processes?	Addresses learning needs professionally and proactively.
How would you describe the leadership culture at The Royal?	Assesses fit and gives you a chance to reinforce your leadership style.

11. Same-day preparation schedule

First 20 minutes: Practise the opening answer, the “why this role” answer, and the explanation of your current-role transition. Keep each answer conversational and under two minutes.

Next 30 minutes: Prepare five stories: Youth Services Bureau operations, staff/performance management, EHR implementation, quality/accreditation, and a complex mental-health situation. For each one, write down the situation, your actions, the result, and one lesson.

Next 20 minutes: Review the Integrated Forensic Program's balance of recovery, risk reduction, and public safety. Refresh the practical interview language for the Mental Health Act, PHIPA, Substitute Decisions Act, privacy, consent, capacity, documentation, and escalation.

Final 15 minutes: Review the keywords, choose four panel questions, check interview logistics, and prepare a closing statement. Do not attempt to memorize every answer; memorize the structure and the examples.

12. Final rapid-review checklist

Before entering the interview, remember to:

- Lead with your **20+ years of progressive experience**, not with a chronological resume recital.
- Present yourself as both a **mental-health expert and an operational leader**.
- Use The Royal connection positively, while showing that your leadership experience extends beyond your current position.
- Connect every operational decision to **patient safety, care quality, staff support, and service continuity**.
- Use **recovery-oriented, trauma-informed, person-centred, risk-aware, and multidisciplinary** language naturally.
- Give concrete examples and include results whenever you can do so accurately.

- Do not overclaim direct forensic-unit management or detailed union/termination experience; show transferable skills and a disciplined approach to learning and process.
- For legal or ethical scenarios, say: assess safety, protect rights and privacy, follow legislation and policy, consult the right experts, document, and follow up.
- For staff issues, say: clarify expectations, listen, coach, document, apply consistent process, involve HR/labour relations, and maintain confidentiality.
- Close by expressing enthusiasm for contributing to The Royal and supporting a safe, recovery-focused, high-performing service.

Closing statement

“Thank you for the opportunity to discuss the role. I believe my combination of mental-health expertise, operational leadership, professional-practice experience, quality-improvement training, and current knowledge of The Royal would allow me to contribute quickly and thoughtfully. I would bring a visible, fair, and collaborative leadership style, with a strong focus on safe patient care, staff development, reliable operations, and measurable improvement. I would be very pleased to support the Integrated Forensic Program and its patients, families, and teams.”

Source note

This guide was tailored exclusively from the supplied job description for The Royal’s Integrated Forensic Program and Anne-Marie Brouse’s 2026 resume. Any examples, metrics, labour-relations details, language proficiency, or program-specific experience should be adjusted to reflect the candidate’s accurate history before use.